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After You

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“After You” by Matt Mills

LISA PAXTON, 41, *a suave, sharp, self-aggrandizing lawyer, stands holding something upright in her right hand.*

Lisa: Rachel. Thank you so much for agreeing to meet me at this time.

Across from her nods *RACHEL TOMPKINS, 37, a spunky, endearing, but acrimonious lawyer standing as tall as she can (Lisa’s taller, but only in the physical sense).*

Rachel: Of course. Should we get started?
Lisa: Absolutely. I motion to record these proceedings for discovery. (*Pulls out her phone*)
Rachel: Motion approved. (*Pulls out her phone*) Motion to double-record these proceedings for optimal post-production mixing and mastering.
Lisa: Motion firmly approved. Alright. (*Clicks her phone, puts it in her pocket*) It is Wednesday, June 28th, 2022 at… (*Peeks at her phone*) Eleven oh seven a.m. I, Lisa Paxton, am willingly engaging in this settlement discussion with intentions to resolve the dispute without trial.
Rachel: I, Rachel Tompkins, am also willingly engaging in this settlement discussion with intentions to resolve the dispute without trial. Alright. How do you plead?
Lisa: After you, your honor. And how do you plead?
Rachel: After *you*, your eminence!
Lisa: Agh. You’re really dragging us to trial instead of just walking through the door I’m holding open for you? Come on! Just go in!
Rachel: Reminder we’re on the record, counselor.
Lisa: Ugh, correct. *Thank you* counselor. Mind if I take opening remarks?
Rachel: You clearly do a remarkable job opening things, so yes. Please do.
Lisa: And you’re great at giving compliments. Okay. (*to an invisible jury)* Let me begin my case–
Rachel: To whom are you presenting your opening argument?
Lisa: Oh. Force of habit. Mind if I keep pretending there’s a jury, though?
Rachel: Motion approved. Motion for me to do the same?
Lisa: Motion approved.

Throughout the proceedings they oscillate from arguing at each other and at imaginary jurors.

Lisa: I will begin by presenting the facts–
Rachel: As you see them.
Lisa: Objection.
Rachel: That’s not how this conversation works and you know it!
Lisa: Sustained. As I see it, the dispute in question arose thusly: On the morning of June 28th, 2022, at approximately… Eleven oh six a.m., I, Lisa Paxton, was approaching this door – the southeastern door of the central conference room on the fourth floor of the Branchwood Hills Office Park in San Contesto, California. As my hand clasped the handle – which, the record should reflect, I am still holding – I observed Rachel Tompkins, a beloved colleague–
Rachel: Objection. You don’t love me.

Lisa: Double-objection! I thought we agreed we weren't doing objections.
Rachel: Sustained. But get to the point, counselor.
Lisa: As I grabbed the door handle, I observed Rachel Tompkins, a colleague whom I *like (Rachel nods approval*), approaching, at which time I offered to hold the door open for Miss Tompkins – an offer which she adamantly and illogically refused and continues to do so!
Rachel: Let the record show that prior to Miss Paxton's hand establishing firm control of the handle and completing the full motion of the clasp, I was more than ten yards away from the play and made a clear, beyond a reasonable doubt gesture encouraging Miss Paxton to go ahead, as holding the door for me was unnecessary and wasted precious seconds of her life.
Lisa: That is patently untrue. There is incredible personal benefit – such an act improves my mental health by providing emotional support to a caring, talented person whom I respect.
Rachel: Regardless, upon my approach I clearly indicated that the right of way was hers with sufficient time for Miss Paxton to change course.
Lisa: Regardless of said communication, my action did not proceed immediately and Miss Tompkins gained proximity to the door in such a rapid fashion that closing of the door would have undoubtedly been deemed a rude gesture.
Rachel: I disagree. The generosity had already been displayed, so there was no need for further sacrifice on the part of Miss Paxton.
Lisa: Let the record show that Miss Tompkins bought me lunch last month and the incident in question was simply one of many small ways in which I am trying to pay her back.
Rachel: Let the record show that Miss Paxton has been an inspiration for a large portion of my career, placing deference on her passage through the door over mine.
Lisa: Motion to not say "Let the record show" anymore because this is being double-recorded and we don't need to.
Rachel: Motion approved. Also, motion to stop making motions.
Lisa: Final motion approved. The truth is, Rachel Tompkins established ownership of this door's passage the day she took me to that new tapas place that I cherish so dearly now.
Rachel: The true pleasure was mine, due to Lisa Paxton's incredible company, making her the rightful first-entrant.
Lisa: Rachel Tompkins donates to more than ten charities, volunteers on the weekends, and has never said an unfair word in my presence, so she should go through the door first.
Rachel: Lisa Paxton deserves to go through the door first because she nursed an ill stray cat back to health and continues to give it a healthy home to this day! Not to mention–
Lisa: Whoa, hey now–
Rachel: May I finish my argument?!
Lisa: (*She settles down*) Proceed.
Rachel: (*She sends some demonstrative looks/reactions) As I was saying*… Lisa sealed ownership as the rightful first entrant of the door when she won the AAJ Partnership Award for her sustained commitments to civil justice!
Lisa: How dare you bring that up. Seriously? Ugh. Come on. That is such a low blow.
Rachel: Hey. Don't dish it if you can't take it.
Lisa: Oh yeah? Well you… I once saw you give a homeless man forty dollars! And he wasn't even asking for money, you just really wanted to make sure he could eat well for a day or whatever – you supported whatever he wanted to do with that money!

Rachel: Alright, if that's how we're gonna play this – just sling old mud at each other…
Lisa: I guarantee I'm dirtier than you.
Rachel: I know you pulled a lot of strings to get that poor girl a scholarship to Columbia!
Lisa: You mentored me even when our firms opposed each other!
Rachel: You protected me from that creepy guy in the bowling alley!
Lisa: You hold the door for people all the time!
Rachel: YOU BRING ENERGY INTO EVERY ROOM YOU WALK INTO!
Lisa: YOU ARE A VERITABLE LIGHT OF A HUMAN BEING!
Rachel: YOUR EXISTENCE RAISES MY FAITH IN HUMANITY!
Lisa: EARTH DOESN'T DESERVE YOU!
Rachel: YOU'RE OUT OF ORDER!
Lisa: YOU'RE OUT OF ORDER!
Rachel: AHHH!!!
Lisa: AHHH!!!
Rachel: –HHH WAIT! Wait. Someone's coming.

Both counselors collect themselves, wiping suits and manufacturing professional posture. They each give polite smiles as some GUY approaches. Lisa curtseys a gesture for him to go in.

Lisa: After you!
Rachel: (*gesturing him in, still holding the door open)* I insist.

Surrounded by their smiles, he walks in without controversy. Their focuses return to each other.

Rachel: Perhaps we're getting a bit bogged down in the details. Allow me to provide some background to my case.
Lisa: The floor is yours, counselor. As is the door.
Rachel: Nice try. Picture if you will… a little girl born in a small town called Elk Horn. Her working parents are home for maybe an hour a night, maybe, if she's lucky. With no resources provided to her, she clawed her way up the educational ladder, shattering the glass ceiling while becoming one of the youngest attorneys in her firm's history. Now tell me – who could possibly deserve to enter a door first *more* than this little girl turned hero – from a place called *Elk Horn!*?
Lisa: I'm glad you ask, counselor. I'll see your little girl and introduce her to one from Anchorage, Alaska. Resilient to freezing temperatures as well as discrimination, she scraped her way into a stunning major lawsuit victory at age 29. When she was only 33, her mother developed a devastating disease that almost took her life – perhaps it would have if not for her daughter, this little girl from Anchorage, dropping everything to do everything for her mother. She has overcome obstacle after obstacle, a lifetime of kicking butt culminating in deserving the ultimate reward: a politely-held door.
Rachel: Your evidence is flimsy and you know it. Exhibit A…CL: You tore your ACL playing rugby in college! I should hold the door for *you*!
Lisa: Exhibit B: My ACL healed properly. Exhibit C: You work incredibly long hours!
Rachel: Exhibit D: You're a treasure I could never live without!
Lisa: A world without you is nothing but a shadow!

Rachel: NO ONE COULD POSSIBLY DESERVE WALKING THROUGH THIS DOOR MORE–
Lisa: YOU'RE AN INSPIRATION!
Rachel: YOU ARE!
Lisa: YOU DESERVE IT!
Rachel: YOU DO!
Lisa: AFTER YOU!
Rachel: AFTER YOU!
Lisa: NO, AFTER YOU!
Rachel: NO, AFTER YOU!
Lisa: I INSIST!
Rachel: I INSIST!
Lisa: I INSIST!!
Rachel: I INSIST!!
Lisa: I INSIST!!!
Rachel: I INSIST!!!!!!

The GUY from earlier returns; it's JEREMY STINTON, 53, a mediator.

Jeremy: Would you PLEASE… either come in or shut the door? (*Lisa and Rachel wince-smile*) We started the deposition five minutes ago and the recorder is picking up your entire argument.
Lisa: We'll be right in.
Rachel: Sorry. (*Jeremy turns to head back in*) Wait. Jeremy! (*Jeremy turns back*) You heard our case, right?
Jeremy: Correct. Unfortunately.
Rachel: So?
Jeremy: What?
Lisa: Who won?
Rachel: You know she deserves to go first–
Lisa: There is nobody that I would rather–
Jeremy: Stop, stop. Wow that's annoying. Fine. Rachel. (*Rachel brightens*) You lose.
Rachel: Awww come on! You know I should go first!
Jeremy: But… but that's what I just decided.
Rachel: Huh?
Lisa: Yeah what?
Jeremy: You were arguing that Lisa should enter the doorway first. I figure that since Lisa, regardless of tardiness of control of the handle, *did* establish control and, as the holder of the door, bore the burden of entering second, as the right of way defers to the person in the same vicinity who possesses superior freedom of movement at that time. Thus, you win, Rachel.
Rachel: Yes. Right. Sorry, I just forgot what we were arguing about for a minute.
Lisa: Yeah, same. In fact… I think I'm feeling a bit lightheaded…
Rachel: Well, hey – let me get that door for you!